



AFP PHOTO

Guarding Against Tigers

DELHI The Palk Bay and the Gulf of Mannar are seeing unprecedented deployment by the Indian Navy and Coast Guard to prevent the ethnic conflict in Sri Lanka from spilling over to India. A total of five patrol vessels including two naval missile corvettes, Dornier aircraft and hovercraft have been deployed along the coast.

With the IAF setting up eight radar stations along the south coast and the navy lengthening the airstrip at Ramnad,

India's southern border is now the most heavily watched Indian boundary. It comes amidst the LTTE targeting Indian fishermen—five were killed last month while 11 others were abducted and their trawler used for gun-running by the LTTE before it was intercepted and sunk by the Maldivian coast guard. An acute shortage of trawlers, has forced the Tigers to hijack Indian vessels for arms transshipment.

Though interrogations

WATER WAR: The Coast Guard keeps close watch

of captured Sea Tigers—of whom at least 11 are in Indian custody—revealed that they have been instructed by the senior LTTE leadership not to engage Indian forces, the authorities say they are not taking any chances. Five Indian fishermen were massacred in April, which was blamed on the Lankan navy but now traced to the LTTE trawler *Mariya* captured by the Coast Guard with five Sea Tigers on board.

Reports from Sri Lanka suggest that the LTTE is readying for a final assault on Jaffna. Last week's attack on Delft Island, one nautical mile away from Indian waters, that hit a Lankan naval base, is believed to be part of this assault plan. The LTTE wants to use all its aerial, land and naval assets in the final thrust and they have also stepped up recruitments. Along the coast, it is better to be forewarned than to be taken by surprise.

by Sandeep Unnithan

Poster Pangs

JAIPUR Rashtriya Vihar Manch's priest Hemant Bohra has found an innovative way to 'deitify' his very mortal idols. His devotion to Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje found expression in Vohra releasing a poster depicting her as Annapurna, while Forest and Environment Minister Laxminarain Dave was portrayed as



PAPER GODDESS: Raje

Kuber and Urban and Development Minister Pratapsingh Singhvi as Indra. Atal Bihari Vajpayee, L.K. Advani and Rajnath Singh were portrayed as Brahma, Vishnu and Mahesh, respectively. However, Sheetal Kanwar, wife of BJP leader Jaswant Singh, has asked for an FIR to be registered against Bohra for hurting public and religious sentiments.

Soon after, Gaj Singh, the erstwhile maharaja of Jodhpur whose name figures as a patron of the Manch, distanced himself from the issue saying he was never associated with the sect. Under pressure, the police have started investigations. Raje, who does not mind being called maharani, seemed amused at being portrayed as a godly poster girl. "I am concerned about the welfare of the people and not about odd individuals criticising or worshipping me," she said.

by Rohit Parihar

OBJECT OF DESIRE



Haute Call

NOKIA 8800 SIROCCO GOLD
Rs 63,299

Capturing the essence of the hot Saharan sirocco, Nokia's 18-carat gold-plated cellphone combines timeless design with contemporary flair. The gold case bathes in the stunning glory of the great African desert wind, blending the sensual beauty of nature with sheer elegance. The fine white gold complements the sapphire-coated, scratch-resistant glass display. On the inside, the Sirocco Gold flaunts a high-resolution camera, a stunning colour screen and a vast array of functionalities in the true Nokia tradition. Comes with a coordinating desk stand and a Bluetooth headset.